FRIENDS OF BISHOP'S PARK

Minutes of Committee Meeting

62 Felden Street | Tuesday 29th September 2026 | 6.30pm

Present: SJ (Chair), Harriet, Sara, Lucy, Georgie, Charles
Apologies: Angela, Alex, Victor

1. Approval of Minutes

The minutes of the previous meeting were approved without amendment.

2. Budget Update

The committee noted a healthy balance of around £10K, which remains fairly steady. It was agreed that FoBP should continue to spend its funds in order to remain compliant with its objectives and Charity Commission guidance. The committee recorded its thanks to Sara for overseeing the accounts so well.

3. Charity Status

The pros and cons of formal charitable registration were discussed. It was noted that Fulham Cemetery Friends are applying for charitable status, which could provide a useful model. FoBP is approaching the £5K annual income threshold at which registration becomes a legal requirement.

Registration would bring benefits — access to grants, higher profile, greater trust, and the ability to receive gift aid (estimated gain of approximately £300 per year) — but also additional obligations including reporting requirements, Charity Commission listing, and director responsibilities, all of which would add to the committee's workload. On balance it was agreed not to apply at present, but to keep the matter under review.

4. Big Bets 2026 — Review and Actions

- Front Beds — the new planting suffered significantly due to the exceptionally dry, hot summer. Agreed to replant with more drought-resistant species. Harriet to investigate suitable options (also applicable to Dave's bed and the long bed at Pryor's Bank).

- **Action** (Harriet): research drought-resistant planting options for the Front Bed, Dave's bed, and the long bed at Pryor's Bank. Tehn we need to discuss with Pauline
- Weekend Gardening Sessions — uptake has been lower than hoped, attributed mainly to lack of publicity. Agreed to increase promotion via Instagram (1,800 followers) and Facebook; sessions are already featured in the membership newsletter. Charles to create a QR code linking to the sign-up page, so that anyone encountered in the Park can be directed straight to it.
- **Action** (SJJ): communicate gardening sessions more widely via Instagram and Facebook
- **Action** (CS): create a QR code linking to the gardening sessions sign-up page
- Tree Signs — not yet completed. Identifying trees via apps has proved extremely time-consuming and difficult; Wikipedia links are easier to use for signage. Agreed to approach the Council's tree officer, Tom, for assistance. A map of trees to be added to the FoBP website.
- **Action** (CS): contact Council tree officer Tom to ask for assistance with tree identification
- FFC Compound Re-opening — the committee agreed not to hold a celebration event. The Compound is now partially open and has been in use for some time, making a formal opening somewhat redundant. The banner issue has also coloured the group's relationship with the Council at present.

5. Big Bets for 2027

- Bare Earth and Re-planting (Bishop's Meadow) — 450 whips from the Woodland Trust grant will arrive in mid-November and will be stored by Pauline at a depot. The application for a further £10K grant (plus a £1K FoBP contribution) to fund Council labour for planting in the bare earth patches at both ends of Bishop's Meadow is still awaited — decision expected in January. If the grant is awarded, planting would take place in February/March. If not, a volunteer effort will be needed, publicised as widely as possible. The plan assumes at least 15% attrition and a 2–3 year establishment phase.
- Friends' Open Afternoons — agreed to progress, with a focus on smaller, more frequent events to build volunteer groups and membership over time. Proposed format: gazebo or table, information leaflets or repurposed postcards with a QR code, cupcakes from the Tea House, a children's park quiz with a small prize. Aim for approximately once a month to begin with. Clearance from the Events Team will be required. First proposed date: 10th or 11th April. Volunteers to be recruited from the membership and other groups.
- **Action** (All): agree date, logistics, and Events Team clearance for the first Friends' Open Afternoon
- Rose Garden Plinths — agreed it is a good idea but too much to take on for 2027. Georgie to carry out some preliminary research in the meantime.
- **Action** (Georgie): carry out preliminary research on Rose Garden plinths

6. Planting

Agreed to pursue drought-resistant planting suggestions as above (Harriet leading). For volunteer sessions, it was noted there is still a significant amount of alkanet around Pryor's Bank and the surrounding beds that needs clearing.

- **Action** : check with Pauline on the October walkabout about staves to protect wildflower areas

7.Watering

The committee agreed that watering remains a significant challenge given the increasingly dry summers. Current available options are not adequate. It was proposed that FoBP funds could be used to purchase water butts or barrels, which could be stored near the IDV area.

- **Action** (CS & Harriet): carry out a walkabout to assess watering options and suitable locations for water butts or barrel

8. Duck Food Bagging

The committee agreed not to pursue an automatic dispenser, as FoBP would receive only 10% of profit and it could create tension with the Tea House. Lucy has kindly agreed to assist Sara with in-person and community bagging sessions as an alternative. Some members are happy to fill bags at home, ordering from Ark Wildlife and collecting bags and labels from the Tea House. Sara will reimburse any invoiced expenditure.

9. Litter and Bin Flaps

There was general scepticism that the Council is making any meaningful progress on bin flaps, despite assurances bin flaps are ordered. It was noted that larger bins are still needed in the summer months for bulky bags. The idea of direct action to fit bin flaps and supply bins ourselves was raised but decided against.

GS to update at next meeting.

10. AGM — 4th November

The AGM was confirmed for 4th November, with doors opening from 5.30pm for set-up and the meeting starting at 6pm. Entry for members is free; a £10 donation is suggested for non-members.

- SJJ to confirm arrangements with TPG and agree an appropriate contribution in recognition of their support (£100, as per last time) (already underway)

- Confirm Seal Watch speaker with reduced speaking time - SJ contacted already
- Confirmed re-election process and Christopher Hancock will announce
- Bring wine coolers and screen, plus left over wine from last year
- Georgie to purchase M&S nibbles, wine, beer, soft drinks and glasses from Majestic — Sara has provided guidance - last we spent £84 M&S, £48 Majestic
- Christmas notelets to be sold on the night.
- Rota needed for door entry.
- Pre-AGM online call: Tuesday 20th October at 6.30pm.

- **Action** (SJJ): confirm AGM arrangements with TPG and agree contribution (£100) - in progress
- **Action** (SJJ): confirm Seal Watch speaker - in progress
- **Action** (Georgie): purchase refreshments from M&S and Majestic for the AGM

11. Committee Membership

It was agreed that the committee would benefit from a couple of additional members. Caroline was proposed as a possible new member.

- **Action** (Lucy & Harriet): follow up with Caroline about joining the committee

12. Volunteer Christmas Thank You

Agreed to hold a volunteer thank-you gathering, following the success of last year's event. Date tbc after the litter pick, at the Tea House. RSVPs will be needed for catering numbers. Last year we spent £82 on tea and drinks.

- **Action** (SJJ): Propose date and check availability with the Tea House for a Sunday tea

13. FFC Lunch Offer

Agreed working in partnership with FFC made strategic sense but an expensive lunch felt out of place. SJJ contacting FFC to suggest a conversation over coffee.

14. Next Meetings

- Walkabout — Monday 12th October, 4.30pm (please confirm attendance)
- Pre-AGM call — Tuesday 20th October, 6.30pm (online)
- AGM — 4th November, from 5.30pm (set-up); 6.00pm (start)
- Committee Meeting Tuesday 2nd February 2027, 6.30pm (in person)